SlyMail User Manual

QWK Offline Mail Reader

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SlyMail User Manual

Introduction

SlyMail is a cross-platform text-based offline mail reader for the QWK packet format. QWK packets are used to exchange mail on Bulletin Board Systems (BBSes). SlyMail provides a full-featured interface for reading, searching, and replying to messages from QWK mail packets.

Its user interface is inspired by Digital Distortion Message Reader (DDMsgReader) for message reading and SlyEdit for message editing, both originally created for Synchronet BBS.

SlyMail runs on Linux, macOS, BSD, and Windows.

Getting Started

Launching SlyMail

SlyMail Opening Screen

Launch SlyMail from the command line:

```
slymail
```

This shows the splash screen (if enabled) and opens the file browser to select a QWK packet.

To open a specific QWK packet directly:

```
slymail MYBBS.qwk
```

Or use the named parameter:

```
slymail -qwk_file=/path/to/MYBBS.qwk
```

Other command-line options:

- `-v` or `--version` - Show version information
- `-?` or `--help` - Show help

The SlyMail Data Directory

On first run, SlyMail creates a data directory at `~/.slymail` (on Linux, macOS, and BSD) or in your home directory on Windows. This directory contains:

- `slymail.ini` - Your settings
- `QWK/` - Default directory for QWK mail packets
- `REP/` - Default directory for reply packets
- `config_files/` - Color theme files
- `dictionary_files/` - Spell-check dictionaries
- `tagline_files/` - Tagline files
- `remote_systems.json` - Saved remote system connections
- `lastread_<BBSID>.json` - Last-read message pointers per conference

The Configuration Program

SlyMail includes a standalone configuration program called `config` (or `slymail-config` if installed via `make install`). This program provides a text-based interface for configuring all SlyMail settings without opening the main application.

Run it from the command line:

```
config
```

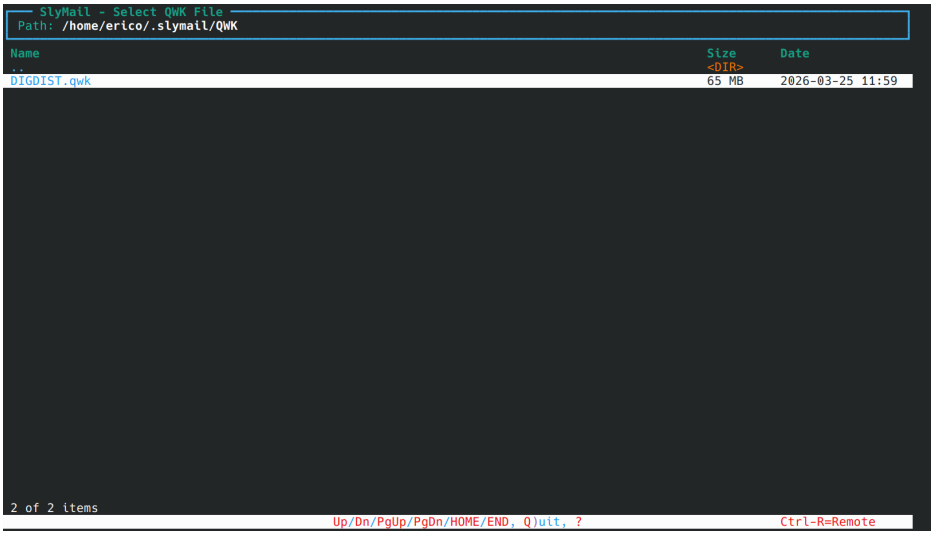
The configuration program offers these categories:

- **Editor Settings** - Editor style, taglines, spell-check, quoting options, theme selection
- **Reader Settings** - Kludge lines, tear lines, scrollbar, ANSI stripping, reverse order, attribute code toggles
- **Theme Settings** - Select Ice and DCT color theme files
- **General Settings** - Your name for replies, reply packet directory, external editor configuration, lightbar mode, splash screen

Settings are saved automatically when you exit each category. Both SlyMail and the config program read and write the same `slymail.ini` file.

File Browser

When SlyMail starts, a file browser is displayed for selecting a QWK packet to open.



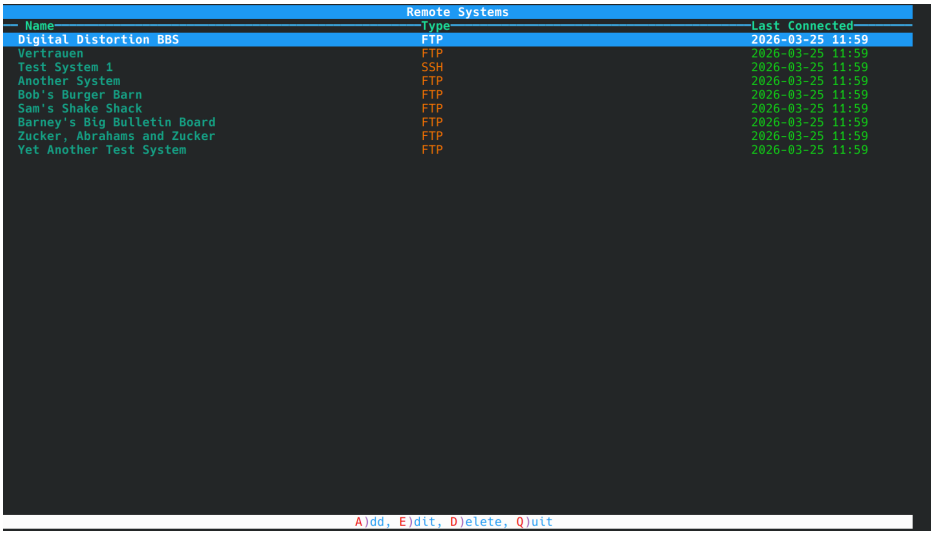
File Browser

File Browser Keys

Key	Action
Up / Down	Navigate files and directories
Enter	Open directory or select a QWK file
PgUp / PgDn	Scroll the file list
Home / End	Jump to first or last entry
Ctrl-R	Open the remote systems directory
Q / ESC	Quit SlyMail
? / F1	Help

Only `.qwk` files can be selected. Directories are shown in blue and can be navigated into by pressing Enter.

Remote Systems (Ctrl-R)



Remote Systems List

SlyMail can download QWK packets directly from remote BBSes via FTP or SFTP (SSH).

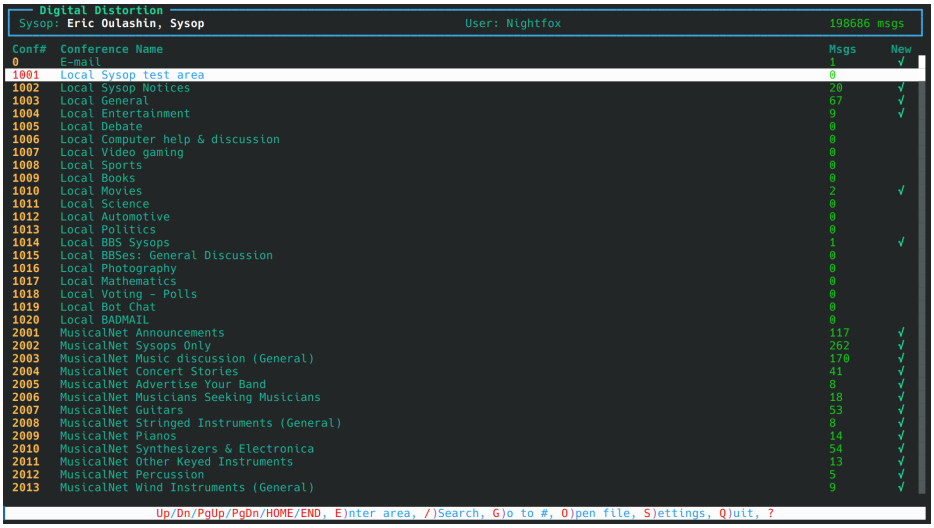
Press **Ctrl-R** from the file browser, conference list, or message list to open the remote systems manager. From here you can:

- **Add** a new remote system with its hostname, port, connection type (FTP or SSH), username, password, passive FTP toggle, and initial remote path
- **Edit** or **Delete** existing entries
- **Connect** to a remote system and browse its directories
- **Download** QWK files directly into your `QWK/` directory
- **Upload** REP reply packets to the remote system

Remote system entries are saved in `remote_systems.json` in your SlyMail data directory. The last connection date/time is tracked for each system.

SlyMail uses the system's `curl` command for FTP and SFTP file transfers.

Conference List



Conference List

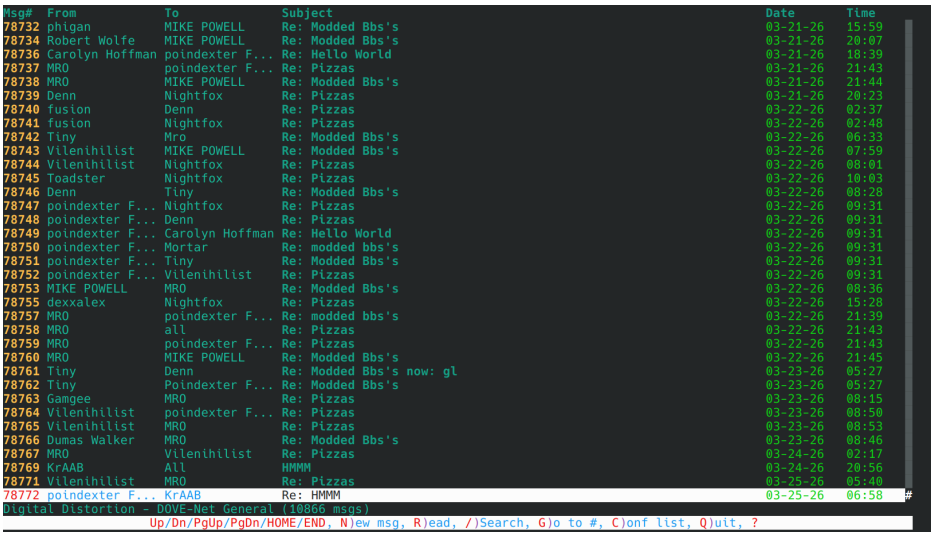
After opening a QWK packet, the conference list shows all message areas (conferences) with their message counts. A “New” column displays a checkmark next to conferences that have new messages. If the “Only show areas with new mail” setting is enabled, conferences with zero messages are hidden.

Conference List Keys

Key	Action
Up / Down	Navigate conferences
PgUp / PgDn	Scroll the list
Home / End	Jump to first or last conference
Enter (E)	Open the selected conference
G	Go to a specific conference number
/	Search conferences by name
V	View polls and votes in the packet
O / Ctrl-L	Open a different QWK file
Ctrl-R	Open remote systems
Ctrl-P	Save the REP reply packet
S / Ctrl-U	Open settings
Q / ESC	Quit SlyMail
? / F1	Help

When a search filter is active, pressing **Q** clears the filter instead of quitting.

Message List



Message List

The message list shows all messages in the selected conference with columns for message number, from, to, subject, date, and time.

Last-Read Message Tracking

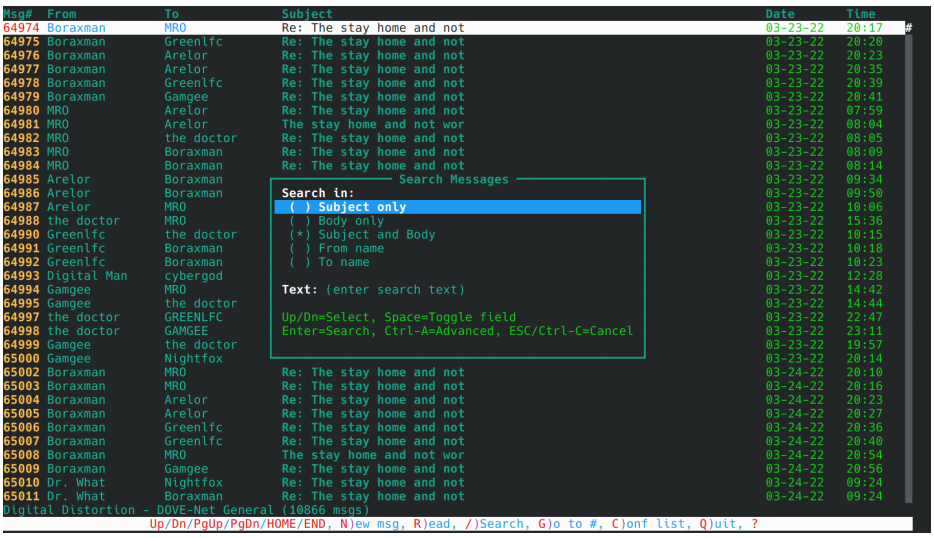
SlyMail remembers the last message you read in each conference. When you enter a conference, the cursor is automatically positioned at the first unread message (the message after the last one you read). This information is saved per-BBS in the SlyMail data directory.

Message List Keys

Key	Action
Up / Down	Navigate messages
PgUp / PgDn	Scroll the list
Home / End	Jump to first or last message
Enter / R	Read the selected message
N	Write a new message
G	Go to a specific message number
/	Search messages
Ctrl-A	Advanced search (with date range)

Key	Action
Ctrl-L	Open a different QWK file
Ctrl-R	Open remote systems
Ctrl-P	Save the REP reply packet
S / Ctrl-U	Open settings
C / ESC	Back to the conference list
Q	Quit
? / F1	Help

Searching Messages



Message Search

Press / to search messages by subject, body text, sender, or recipient. Press **Ctrl-A** for advanced search, which includes date range filtering with a visual calendar date picker. When a search filter is active, pressing **Q** clears the filter.

The search can use plain substring matching or regular expressions, depending on the “Search using regular expression” setting.

Message Reader

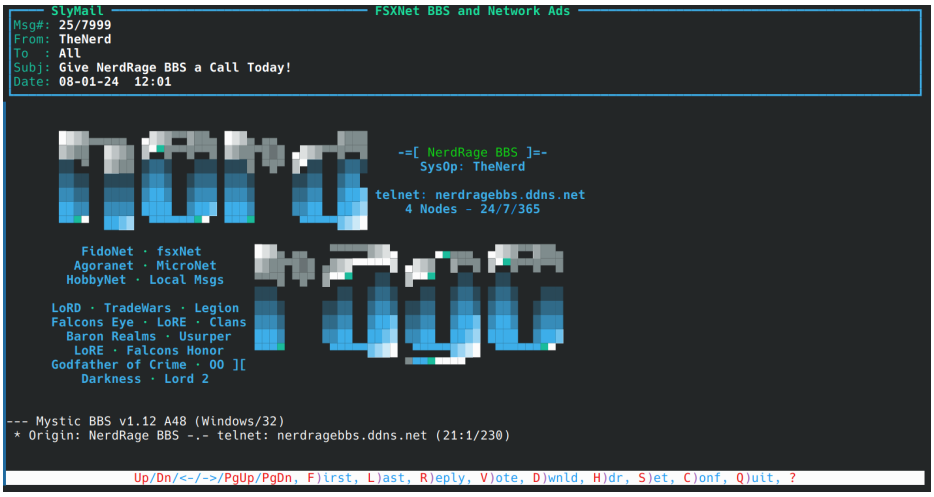
Reading a Message

The message reader displays message content with a header showing From, To, Subject, and Date fields.

Message Reader Keys

Key	Action
Up / Down	Scroll message content
PgUp / PgDn	Page up or down
Home / End	Jump to top or bottom
Left / Right	Previous or next message
F / L	First or last message
R	Reply to the message
V	Vote (up/down vote or poll ballot)
D / Ctrl-D	Download file attachments
H	Show detailed message header
S / Ctrl-U	Open settings
C / Q / ESC / M	Back to the message list
? / F1	Help

ANSI Art



ANSI Art

SlyMail renders ANSI art in messages, supporting cursor positioning, colors, and CP437 block characters. Messages containing ANSI cursor control sequences are automatically detected and rendered through a virtual screen buffer for proper display.

File Attachments

When a message has file attachments (indicated by **[ATT]** in the header), press **D** or **Ctrl-D** to view and download them. You will be shown a list of attached files with their sizes and prompted to select a destination directory.

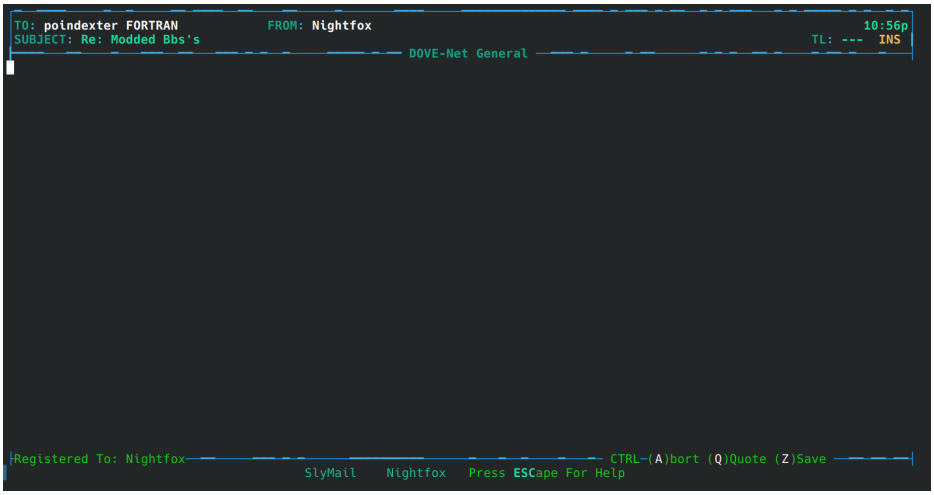
Voting and Polls

SlyMail supports Synchronet-style voting:

- **Polls**: Messages identified as polls display answer options with vote counts and percentage bars. Press **V** to open a ballot dialog where you can toggle your selections and cast your vote.
- **Up/Down Votes**: For regular messages, press **V** to up-vote or down-vote. Current vote tallies and net score are shown in the header.
- **Poll Browser**: Press **V** from the conference list to browse all polls in the packet.

Votes are queued alongside message replies and written to the REP packet.

Message Editor



Message Editor

The message editor is used for composing replies and new messages. It offers two visual modes inspired by SlyEdit: **Ice** mode and **DCT** mode.

Editor Keys

Key	Action
Arrow keys	Move the cursor
Home / End	Beginning or end of line
PgUp / PgDn	Page up or down
Insert	Toggle Insert/Overwrite mode
Delete	Delete character at cursor
Backspace	Delete character before cursor
ESC	Open the editor menu
Ctrl-Z	Save the message
Ctrl-A	Abort the message
Ctrl-Q	Open or close the quote window
Ctrl-K	Open the color picker
Ctrl-G	Insert a CP437 graphic character
Ctrl-O	Import a text file at the cursor position
Ctrl-W	Search for text
Ctrl-S	Change the subject
Ctrl-D	Delete the current line
Ctrl-T	List text replacements

Key	Action
Ctrl-U	Open editor settings
F1	Help screen

Slash Commands

You can also type slash commands on an empty line and press Enter:

Command	Action
/S	Save the message
/A	Abort the message
/Q	Open the quote window
/U	Open editor settings
/?	Show help

Quote Window

Quote Window

When replying to a message, press **Ctrl-Q** or type `/Q` on an empty line to open the quote window. The quote window shows the original message text with quote prefixes.

Key	Action
Up / Down	Navigate quote lines
PgUp / PgDn	Page up or down
Home / End	Jump to first or last line
Enter	Insert the selected quote line into your message

Key	Action
Ctrl-Q / ESC	Close the quote window

If the number of quote lines exceeds the quote window height, a scrollbar appears on the right edge.

Color Picker (Ctrl-K)

Press **Ctrl-K** to open an interactive color picker dialog. Select a foreground color (16 options: 8 normal + 8 bright) and a background color (8 options). A live preview shows the selected combination. Press **Enter** to insert the ANSI color code at the cursor position. Press **N** to insert a reset (normal) code.

File Import (Ctrl-O)

Press **Ctrl-O** to import the contents of a text file into your message at the current cursor position. A file browser opens to let you select any file. The file's contents are inserted line by line at the cursor, preserving line breaks.

Editing a message

Quote Line Handling

When replying to a message, lines inserted from the quote window are tracked as quote lines. If you edit a quote line and it wraps, the overflow goes onto a new line (also marked as a quote line) rather than merging with adjacent text. Deleting text from a quote line will not pull text up from the next line if it is also a quote line. This preserves the integrity of quoted text.

Paragraph-Based Saving

When saving a message, SlyMail joins soft-wrapped lines of newly typed text into single long paragraphs. This allows other people's mail readers to re-wrap the text to fit their own terminal width. Quote lines are always preserved exactly as they appear and are never joined.

Empty Messages

If you save a message that has no text content (empty or whitespace only), SlyMail aborts the message and shows a notification instead of posting it.

External Editors

SlyMail supports using external text editors instead of the built-in editor. To configure an external editor:

1. Open Settings (Ctrl-U or the config program)
2. Go to **External Editors...** to add and configure editors
3. Set the **External Editor** to select which configured editor to use
4. Enable **Use external editor**

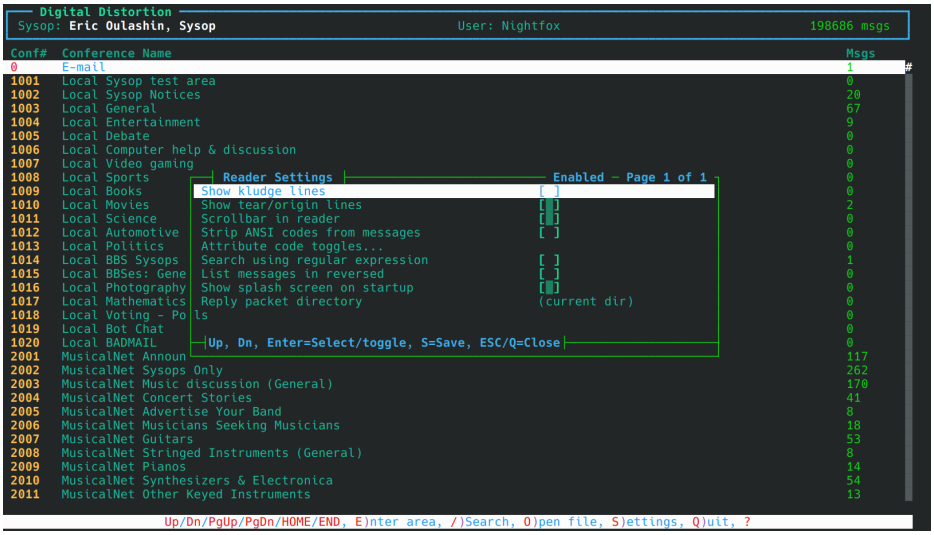
Each external editor can be configured with:

- **Name** - A descriptive name for the editor
- **Startup Directory** - The directory containing the editor executable
- **Command Line** - The command to run (use `%f` for the temp file path)
- **Word-wrap Quoted Text** - Whether to word-wrap quoted text and the column width
- **Auto Quoted Text** - Always include quotes, prompt each time, or never include them
- **Editor Information Files** - Drop file type (None, MSGINF, EDITOR.INF, DOOR.SYS, DOOR32.SYS)
- **Strip FidoNet Kludges** - Remove FidoNet control lines from quoted text

When using an external editor, SlyMail creates a temporary file, launches the editor, and reads the result when the editor exits. If the editor produces a `RESULT.ED` file (Synchronet-compatible), SlyMail reads the new subject and editor details from it.

Settings

Reader Settings (Ctrl-U)



Reader Settings

Access reader settings by pressing **Ctrl-U** or **S** from the conference list, message list, or message reader.

Available settings:

- **Show kludge lines** - Show or hide kludge/control lines in messages
- **Show tear/origin lines** - Show or hide tear and origin lines
- **Scrollbar in reader** - Show or hide the scrollbar
- **Only show areas with new mail** - Hide conferences with zero messages
- **Strip ANSI codes from messages** - Remove all ANSI escape sequences
- **Attribute code toggles** - Enable/disable BBS color code interpretation per type
- **Search using regular expression** - Use regex for searches
- **List messages in reversed** - Show newest messages first
- **Show splash screen on startup** - Toggle the splash screen
- **Reply packet directory** - Set the directory for saving REP packets
- **Use external editor** - Enable external editor mode
- **External Editors...** - Configure external editors
- **External Editor** - Select which configured editor to use

Press **S** to save settings, or **ESC/Q** to close (with a prompt to save if changes were made).

Editor Settings (Ctrl-U in Editor)

Access editor settings by pressing **Ctrl-U** while in the message editor.

Available settings:

- **Choose UI mode** - Switch between Ice, DCT, and Random styles
- **Taglines** - Enable tagline insertion when saving
- **Spell-check dictionary/dictionaries** - Select which dictionaries to use
- **Prompt for spell checker on save** - Enable spell-check prompting
- **Wrap quote lines to terminal width** - Word-wrap quoted lines
- **Quote with author's initials** - Use initials-based quote prefixes
- **Indent quote lines containing initials** - Add leading space before initials
- **Trim spaces from quote lines** - Strip leading whitespace from quotes

BBS Color Code Support

SlyMail interprets color and attribute codes from multiple BBS software packages:

- **ANSI escape codes** - Always enabled; standard SGR sequences
- **Synchronet Ctrl-A codes** - Ctrl-A + attribute character
- **WWIV heart codes** - Ctrl-C + digit 0-9
- **PCBoard/Wildcat @X codes** - @X followed by two hex digits
- **Celerity pipe codes** - Pipe + letter
- **Renegade pipe codes** - Pipe + two-digit number

Each code type can be individually enabled or disabled via the Attribute Code Toggles sub-dialog in settings.

Color Themes

SlyMail's editor uses configurable color themes loaded from `.ini` files in the `config_files/` directory.

Ice Themes

Ice themes control the appearance of the Ice editor mode:

- BlueIce (default)

- EmeraldCity
- FieryInferno
- Fire-N-Ice
- GeneralClean
- GenericBlue
- PurpleHaze
- ShadesOfGrey

DCT Themes

DCT themes control the appearance of the DCT editor mode:

- Default
- Default-Modified
- Midnight

Theme Color Format

Theme colors use a compact format based on Synchronet attribute codes:

- `n` - Normal (reset all attributes)
- Foreground letters: `k`=black, `r`=red, `g`=green, `y`=yellow, `b`=blue, `m`=magenta, `c`=cyan, `w`=white
- `h` - High/bright intensity
- Background digits: `0`=black, `1`=red, `2`=green, `3`=brown, `4`=blue, `5`=magenta, `6`=cyan, `7`=light gray

Examples: `nbh` = bright blue, `n4wh` = bright white on blue background, `nk7` = black on light gray

Spell Checker

SlyMail includes a built-in spell checker using plain-text dictionary files.

Dictionaries

Dictionary files are stored in `dictionary_files/`:

- `dictionary_en.txt` - English (general)
- `dictionary_en-US-supplemental.txt` - US English supplement
- `dictionary_en-GB-supplemental.txt` - British English supplement

- `dictionary_en-AU-supplemental.txt` - Australian English supplement
- `dictionary_en-CA-supplemental.txt` - Canadian English supplement

Multiple dictionaries can be selected simultaneously for combined word coverage.

Using the Spell Checker

Enable “Prompt for spell checker on save” in settings. When you save a message, the spell checker scans for misspelled words and presents options for each:

- **R**eplace - Type a replacement word
- **S**kip - Skip this word
- **Q**uit - Stop spell checking

Taglines

Taglines are short quotes or sayings appended to messages when saved.

Setup

1. Enable “Taglines” in editor settings
2. Place taglines in `tagline_files/taglines.txt`, one per line
3. Lines starting with `#` or `;` are treated as comments

Usage

When saving a message with taglines enabled, you are prompted to select a specific tagline or choose one at random. The selected tagline is appended to your message with a `...` prefix.

REP Reply Packets

When you write replies or new messages, they are queued as pending. Votes (poll ballots, up/down votes) are also queued.

Saving REP Packets

- Press **Ctrl-P** from the conference or message list to save the REP packet at any time
- SlyMail prompts to save after composing a message
- On exit, SlyMail prompts to save any unsaved pending items

The REP packet is saved as `<BBS-ID>.rep` in your configured reply directory (defaulting to `~/.slymail/REP/`). Upload this file back to the BBS to post your replies.

REP Packet Contents

- Message replies in standard QWK format
- `HEADERS.DAT` for extended fields exceeding 25 characters
- `VOTING.DAT` for pending votes (Synchronet-compatible)

UTF-8 Support

SlyMail detects and displays UTF-8 content correctly:

- UTF-8 messages are detected via `HEADERS.DAT` flags and automatic byte sequence analysis
- A **[UTF8]** indicator appears in the message header for UTF-8 messages
- CP437 characters from legacy BBS content are converted to their Unicode equivalents for proper display in modern terminals

Settings File Reference

Settings are stored in `slymail.ini` in the SlyMail data directory. The file uses INI format with sections:

[General]

Setting	Default	Description
showSplashScreen	true	Show splash screen on startup
userName	(empty)	Your name for the From field in replies
replyDir	(empty)	Directory for saving REP packets
useExternalEditor	false	Use external editor instead of built-in

Setting	Default	Description
selectedEditor	(empty)	Name of the selected external editor

[Reader]

Setting	Default	Description
showKludgeLines	false	Show kludge/control lines
showTearLine	true	Show tear and origin lines
useScrollbar	true	Show scrollbar in message reader
onlyShowAreasWithNewMail	false	Hide empty conferences
stripAnsi	false	Strip ANSI codes from messages
attrSynchronet	true	Interpret Synchronet Ctrl-A codes
attrWWIV	true	Interpret WWIV heart codes
attrCelerity	true	Interpret Celerity pipe codes
attrRenegade	true	Interpret Renegade pipe codes
attrPCBoard	true	Interpret PCBoard/Wildcat @X codes
useRegexSearch	false	Use regex for searches

[MessageList]

Setting	Default	Description
lightbarMode	true	Lightbar navigation in message list
reverseOrder	false	Show newest messages first

[Editor]

Setting	Default	Description
editorStyle	Ice	Editor mode: Ice, Dct, or Random
insertMode	true	Default insert mode
wrapQuoteLines	true	Word-wrap quoted lines

Setting	Default	Description
quoteLineWidth	76	Max width for quote lines
quotePrefix	> (space)	Quote line prefix
taglines	false	Enable tagline insertion
promptSpellCheck	false	Prompt for spell check on save
quoteWithInitials	false	Use author initials in quote prefix
indentQuoteInitials	true	Add space before initials
trimQuoteSpaces	false	Trim whitespace from quote lines

[Themes]

Setting	Default	Description
iceThemeFile	EditorIceColors_BlueIce.ini	Ice mode theme file
dctThemeFile	EditorDCTColors_Default.ini	DCT mode theme file

Synchronet BBS QWK Settings

If using a Synchronet BBS, the following QWK packet settings are recommended for best compatibility with SlyMail:

Setting	Recommended Value
Ctrl-A Color Codes	Leave in
Archive Type	ZIP
Include File Attachments	Yes
Include Index Files	Yes
Include Control Files	Yes
Include VOTING.DAT File	Yes
Include HEADERS.DAT File	Yes
Include UTF-8 Characters	Yes
Extended (QWKE) Packet Format	Yes

Changelog

Version 0.54 (2026-03-31)

Added

- Last-read message tracking per conference with automatic cursor positioning
- New message indicator (checkmark column) in the conference list
- File import in message editor (Ctrl-O) to insert text files at cursor position
- Quote line tracking to preserve quote line integrity during editing
- Paragraph-based message saving for better text reflow by recipients
- Terminal resize detection: This allows SlyMail to resize its window(s) and contents in response to the terminal window being resized.

Changed

- Quote line wrapping now respects terminal width when enabled
- Configuration on first start: If the user doesn't have any SlyMail settings yet (i.e., their .slymail directory doesn't exist yet), config will run on startup, and the user's name will be asked before continuing on into configuration settings.

Fixed

- Quote line editing no longer merges overflow with adjacent lines

Version 0.53 (2026-03-29)

Added

- Setting to only show conferences with new messages
- External editor support with multiple editor configurations
- Drop file type support (MSGINF, EDITOR.INF, DOOR.SYS, DOOR32.SYS)
- RESULT.ED parsing after external editor exits
- Go-to conference number (G key) in conference list
- Digit-only input validation for Go-to prompts

Fixed

- Slash commands (/Q, /S, etc.) now work on the first line of the editor
- DCT quote window colors now use the loaded theme correctly
- Quote window scrollbar restored for long quote lists
- Improved screen refresh in settings dialogs

Version 0.52 (2026-03-26)

Added

- REP directory created automatically
- Save REP packet hotkey (Ctrl-P)
- Upload reply packets to remote systems
- Quote line re-wrapping
- Directory chooser for reply packet directory

Changed

- Faster editor screen updates with reduced flicker
- Paragraph-aware message saving
- Improved ANSI rendering with 256-color and truecolor support

Fixed

- Editor color code handling during all editing operations
- Editor word wrap behavior
- Quote prefix trailing space preservation
- REP save tracking

Version 0.51 (2026-03-25)

Added

- QWKE (Extended QWK) support
- BBS color/attribute code support for multiple BBS types
- Synchronet voting support (polls and up/down votes)
- File attachment support
- UTF-8 support
- Color picker (Ctrl-K)
- Remote systems directory (Ctrl-R)
- Search and filtering with advanced search
- Splash screen toggle

Version 0.50 (2026-03-24)

- Initial release
- Cross-platform QWK offline mail reader
- DDMsgReader-inspired reading interface
- SlyEdit-inspired message editor with Ice and DCT modes
- Theme support, spell checker, and taglines
- REP reply packet creation
- File browser and standalone config utility